



Age restrictions for Facebook's registration

Due to FTC regulation changes, we had to implement changes on the Facebook registration flow that required people to be at least 13 years old when signing up.

Previously, people were able to enter any birthday and proceed. This urgently had to be changed to meet new FTC regulation.

12:49

81

<

What's your name?

Enter the name you use in real life.

First name

|

Last name

Next

September	5	2020
October	6	2021
November	7	2022
December	8	2023
January	9	2024
February	10	2025
March	11	2026
April	12	2027

Challenges

Introduce stricter rules on age requirements

Work with the FTC (and other regulatory bodies) to ensure our registration flows adhered to a minimum age of 13 in order to make a Facebook account.

Mitigate extra friction from new rules

While the new changes were for a good cause, we knew these changes would introduce higher friction than the existing experience which currently let people quickly skip past the date of birth screen.

Goals

What does success look like?

- Reduce the amount of underage sign-ups
- Minimize negative impact on core growth metrics

My involvement

As the lead Product Designer, I worked with product owners, engineers and researchers to design multiple tests, some of which eventually shipped globally and are still in production today.

Key insights

Some rural areas in India (one of Facebook's biggest growth markets) couldn't recall their birthday and often didn't have birth certificates.

People were concerned about sharing this personal information with Facebook and would sometimes input false data.

Design principles

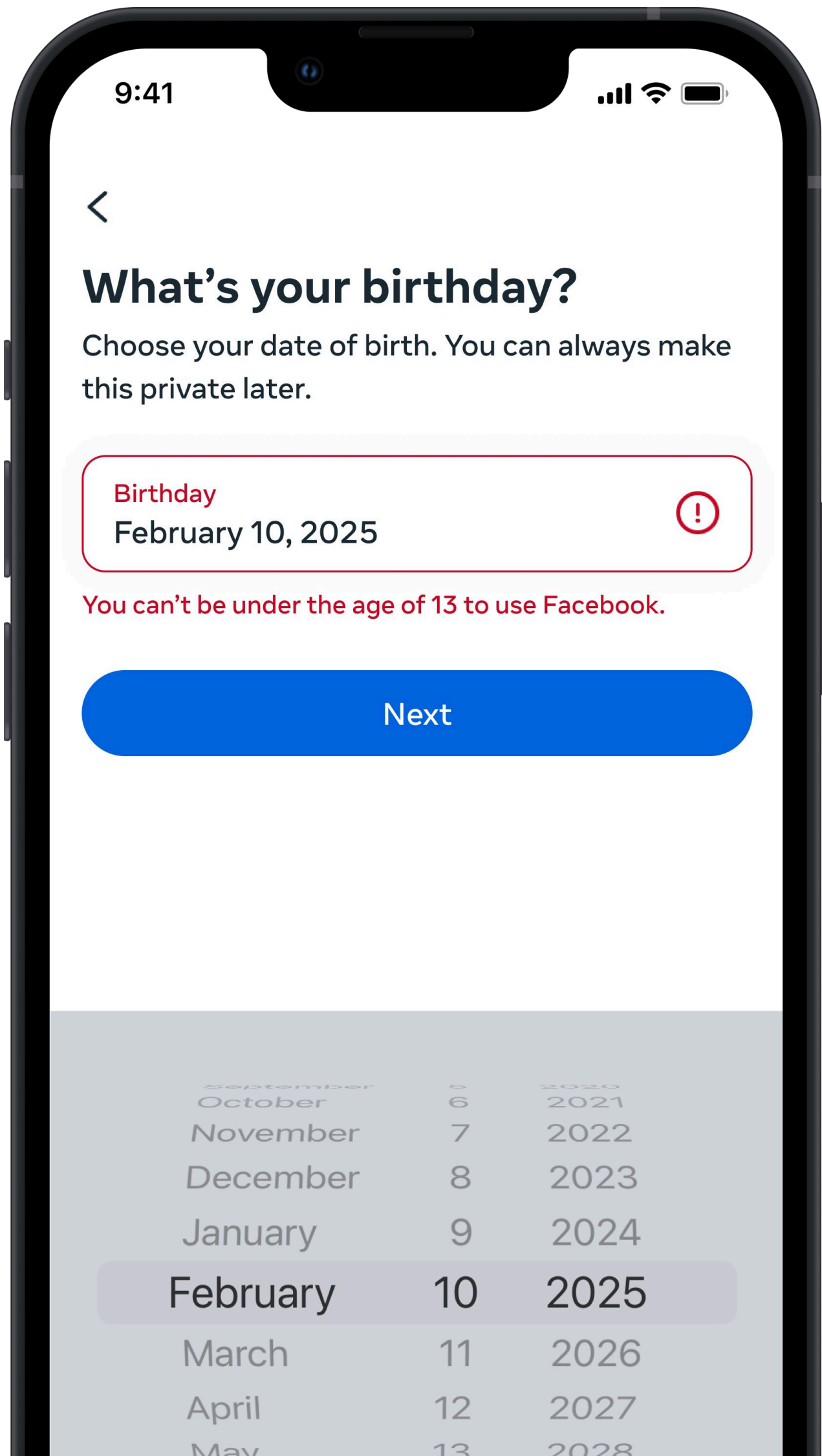
Simple. Make the design simple enough to prevent further alienating developing countries.

Transparent. Communicate how and why this birthday data is being collected.

Actionable. Provide actionable paths through this page instead of roadblocks.

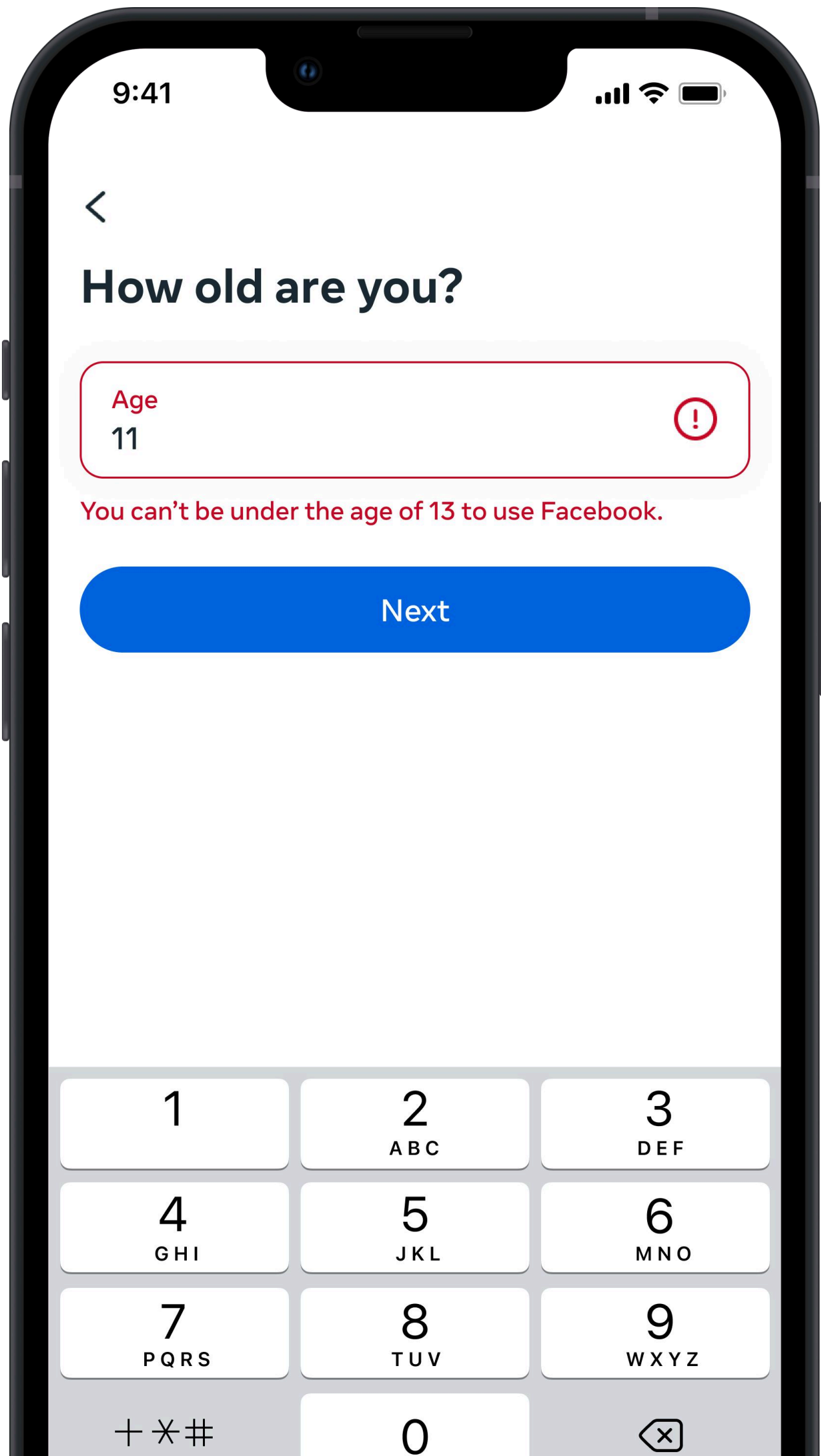
Option 1 - date picker

Here, we explored basic inline validation to explain why they can't proceed to the next page due to the age restriction.



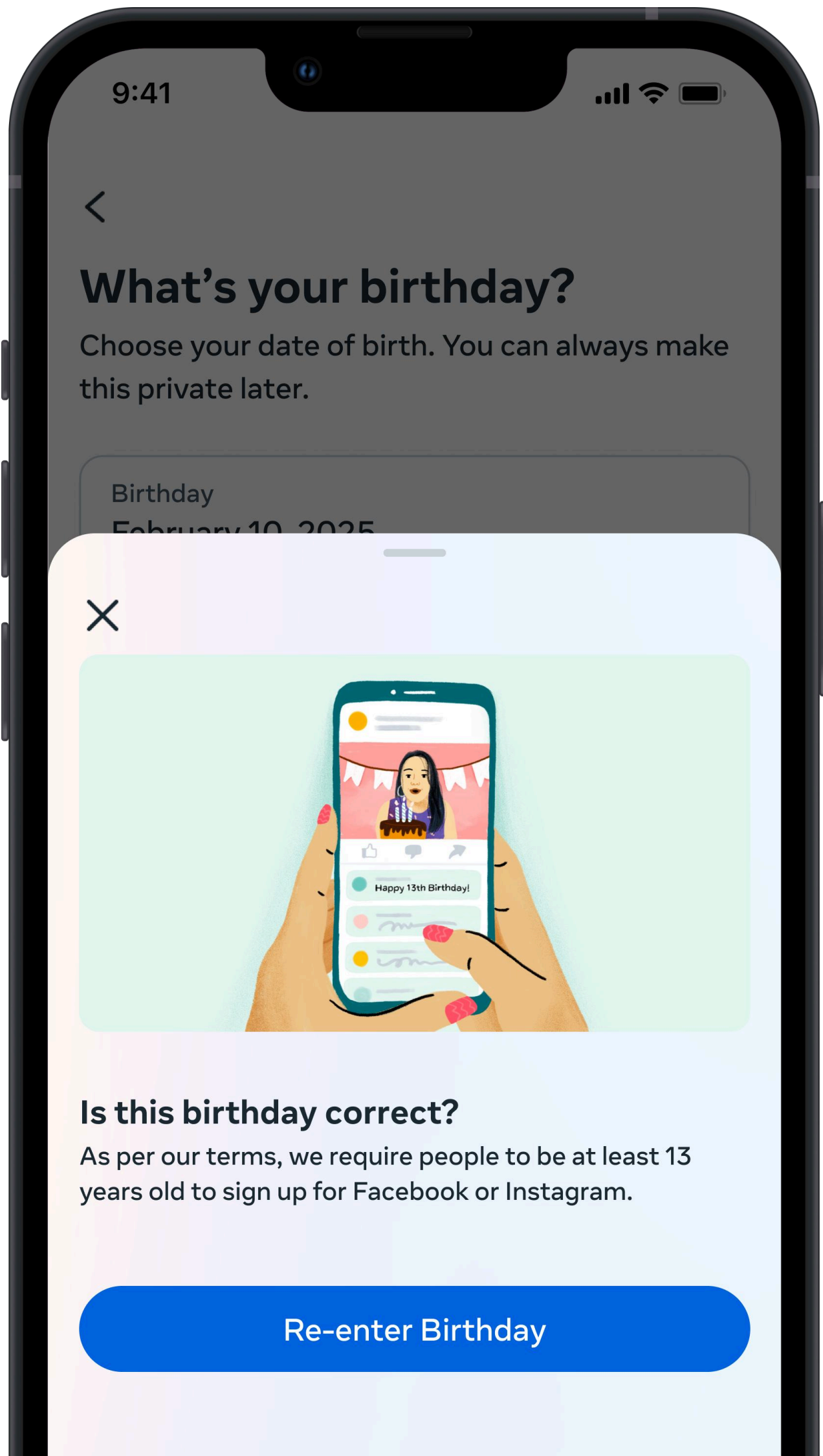
Option 2 - number selector

This version explored entering a numerical value for age instead of a traditional date picker.



Option 3 - helper link

Upon multiple failed attempts, we explored prompting a helper sheet to provide additional context in a more direct way.





Testing the designs in India

User testing & contextual inquiries

Given most of our registration traffic is from India, we traveled there with prototypes in-hand ready to test.

Takeaways

- V2 (number selector) had a higher completion rate
- Error messages weren't perceived well
- People from rural areas didn't know their birthday

NEXT ITERATION

Refining the concept based on our research

While we were happy with the simpler direction of the updated designs, we ran into several issues that the privacy and growth leadership team had kindly pointed out. People coming back on Facebook to look at birthday posts was one of the biggest re-engagement drivers for the app, meaning specificity around birth date was paramount. The lack of a specific birth date also left us in a legally grey area.

9:41

<

How old are you? 

Age
11

You need to be 13 years or older to join Facebook

Next

Use date of birth

1 2 ABC 3 DEF
4 GHI 5 JKL 6 MNO
7 PQRS 8 TUV 9 WXYZ
+ * # 0 

Didn't ship

Audio cues (India only)

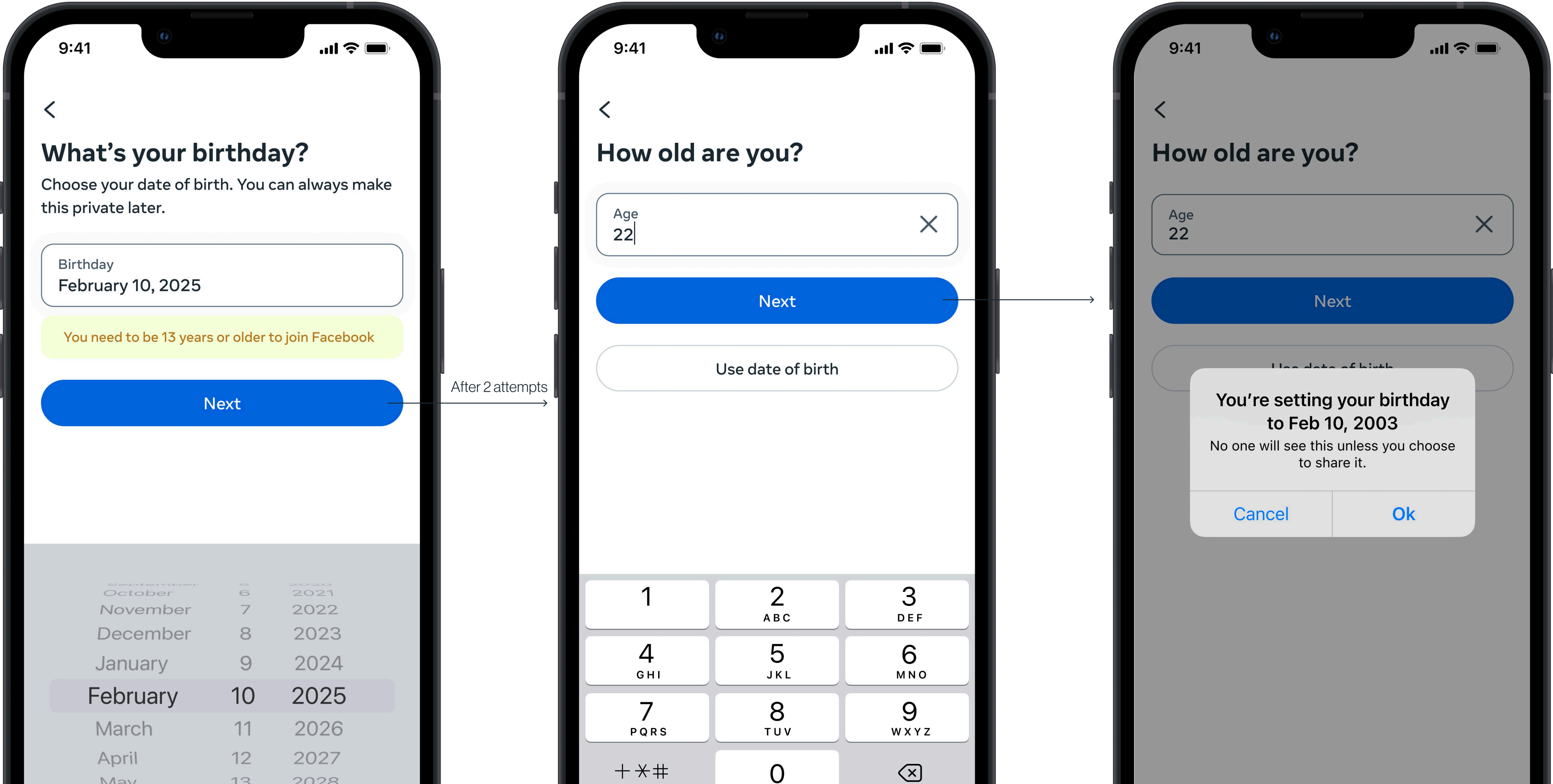
To address the literacy gaps in rural parts of India, we conceptualized audio cues to help better explain what's being asked.

Visually softer validation

We restyled error messages to come across in a more accessible manner.

Hybrid date picker/age input version

Our final version aimed to balance accurate birthday data with ease of use. If people struggled to enter their specific birthday, they could fall back on an easier route via our age input.



9:41

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How old are you?

Age
22

X

Next

Use date of birth

1
2
ABC
3
DEF
4
GHI
5
JKL
6
MNO

Shipped

Product impact

- Prevented negative growth impact to top-line metrics
- Met FTC regulation constraints under tight deadline
- Produced a higher rate of accurate birthdays
- Design was scaled and eventually shipped to Instagram
- Solution flexed for other international regulatory bodies

Detailed metrics confidential due to NDA.



Thank you

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